Electoral math, based on vote share, gives the DMK a decisive advantage. In the 2021 assembly election, the SPA won 45.4 per cent of the votes, a crucial 5.8 percentage points more than the AIADMK-BJP combine.

Reality Bites

The AIADMK is gradually waking up to the harsh realities of politics without power after a decade in government. Since the May 2021 loss, it has realised that the alliance with the BJP is hurting its Dravidian identity, turning it first into a Trojan horse for saffron and then into prey. Meanwhile, internal convulsions led to former deputy CM O. Panneerselvam (OPS) being expelled and ex-CM Edappadi K. Palaniswami (EPS) seizing control as party general secretary. The AIADMK formally broke off with the BJP in September 2023. The existential crisis has only deepened with ally Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) deciding to go with the BJP. The OPS faction, too, has pledged support to the third front, though he has no party to speak of and is fighting as a BJP-backed independent from Ramanathapuram. The AIADMK is now left with minor allies—the late actor Vijayakanth's Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam (DMDK) and the Puthiya Tamizhagam (PT). The 2019 general election, the first after CM and 'Puratchi Thalaivi' J. Jayalalithaa's passing in 2016, had seen the AIADMK reduced to one seat and a vote share of under 20 per cent.

EPS has an uphill task trying to win seats and leverage that into relevance for the 2026 assembly polls. "Our strength is that we have manpower (polling agents) down to the last booth across the state," says ex-minister B.V. Ramana. Another advantage is that many AIADMK contestants are 'resourceful'. With declared assets of Rs 583 crore, the party candidate in Erode, Ashok Kumar, is one of the richest in the state.

The BJP, as is its wont in states where it is seeking a foothold, is looking at incremental gains with Prime Minister Narendra Modi again doing much of

THE FOCUS AREAS

DRAVIDA MUNNETRA KAZHAGAM

- Bring back the focus on Dravidian identity while fielding a mix of heavyweights and fresh faces
- Target the BJP as a threat to federal polity and democracy, and to Dravidian identity, culture
- Highlight language question, tenuous Centre-State ties, governor's overreach, Centre withholding funds
- Get SPA members onboard to boost vote share

ALL INDIA ANNA DRAVIDA MUNNETRA KAZHAGAM

- Target the DMK with allegations of corruption, nepotism and broken poll promises but keep the narrative between the Dravidian parties
- Field candidates who can spend, keeping in mind caste calculations, other micro factors
- Build on the inherent strengths of second-level party leaders and cadre and stage a comeback in 2026

BHARATIYA JANATA PARTY

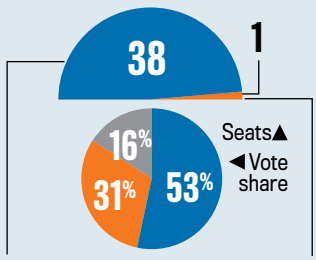
- Target the Dravidian ideology and the DMK and AIADMK which represent it to end their 57 year hegemony in the state
- Rope in former elected representatives and opinion-makers at local level to boost party profile
- Mimic the Dravidian majors, get caste-based parties to join to raise vote share

SOLIDARITY STREET

The Secular Progressive Alliance's ability to transfer votes among the allies has served it well

LOK SABHA 2019

(Total seats: 39)



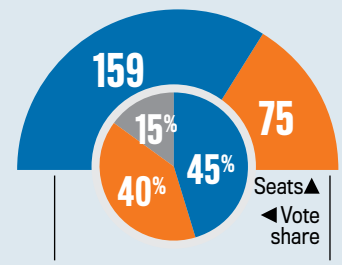
DMK* 23 (34%)
INC 8 (13%)
CPI 2 (2%)
CPI (M) 2 (2%)
VCK 2 (1%)
IUML 1 (1%)

AIADMK 1 (19%)
PMK 0 (5%)
BJP 0 (4%)
DMDK 0 (2%)
PT 0 (1%)

** includes wins by minor allies IJK, KMDK, MDMK*

ASSEMBLY 2021

(Total seats: 234)



DMK 133 (38%)
INC 18 (4%)
CPI 2 (1%)
VCK 4 (1%)
CPI(M) 2 (1%)

AIADMK 66 (33%)
PMK 5 (4%)
BJP 4 (3%)

**Naam Tamizhar Katchi (NTK) contested all 234 seats, got 6.6% of the vote*

Secular Progressive Alliance | National Democratic Alliance | Others

VCK: Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi; IUML: Muslim League; PMK: Pattali Makkal Katchi; DMDK: Desiya Murpokku Dravida Kazhagam; PT: Puthiya Tamilagam

Vote share figures have been rounded off